But perhaps the most telling response was the first one, from Azaria's fellow soldiers—at least one of them an officer, judging by the insignia on his uniform. The B'Tselem video captured their immediate reaction to the unprovoked shooting. Or, to put it more bluntly, their lack of reaction. As Azaria delivered the shot to the head, they didn't even flinch.

The Second Third Intifada

Israelis couldn't even agree on what to call it: the wave of terror, the knife intifada, the lone wolf intifada. Some simply called it the third intifada, though that was problematic, because a few commentators had already labeled the events of the previous winter the third intifada. (The "second third intifada", perhaps?)

However, one thing could not be disputed. It was the worst bout of sustained violence in Israel and the West Bank in more than a decade. Scores of young men and women, most of them armed with knives, struck nearly one hundred times in the first two months—not only in Jerusalem and other perennial hotbeds, but in sleepy suburbs like Petah Tikva and Ra'anana, far from Israel's contested borders. A middle-aged couple was shot dead on a West Bank highway with their four young children in the back seat. A rabbi was hacked to death with a meat cleaver in broad daylight on a busy Jerusalem street. Gunmen ordered dessert in a popular Tel Aviv restaurant, then pulled out their weapons and opened fire, killing four people.

One of the most puzzling aspects of the violence was that nobody seemed to be directing it. Security officials said there was little evidence that any of the attackers were linked to militant groups or political factions. Instead the violence was like a fire that fed itself. At first it had seemed to be a response to religious tensions on the Temple Mount, the site in Jerusalem sacred to both Jews and Muslims (who revere it as *Haram al-Sharif*, the "Noble Sanctuary"). As it continued, assailants told their Israeli interrogators that they had been provoked by the widely-circulated videos of their predecessors being shot dead. The violence subsided after the new year, from an average of three daily attacks to one, but it continued for months at that lower level. "This has become our new normal, even though it isn't normal," said Col Gilad Eisen, who was then the top intelligence officer in the West Bank.